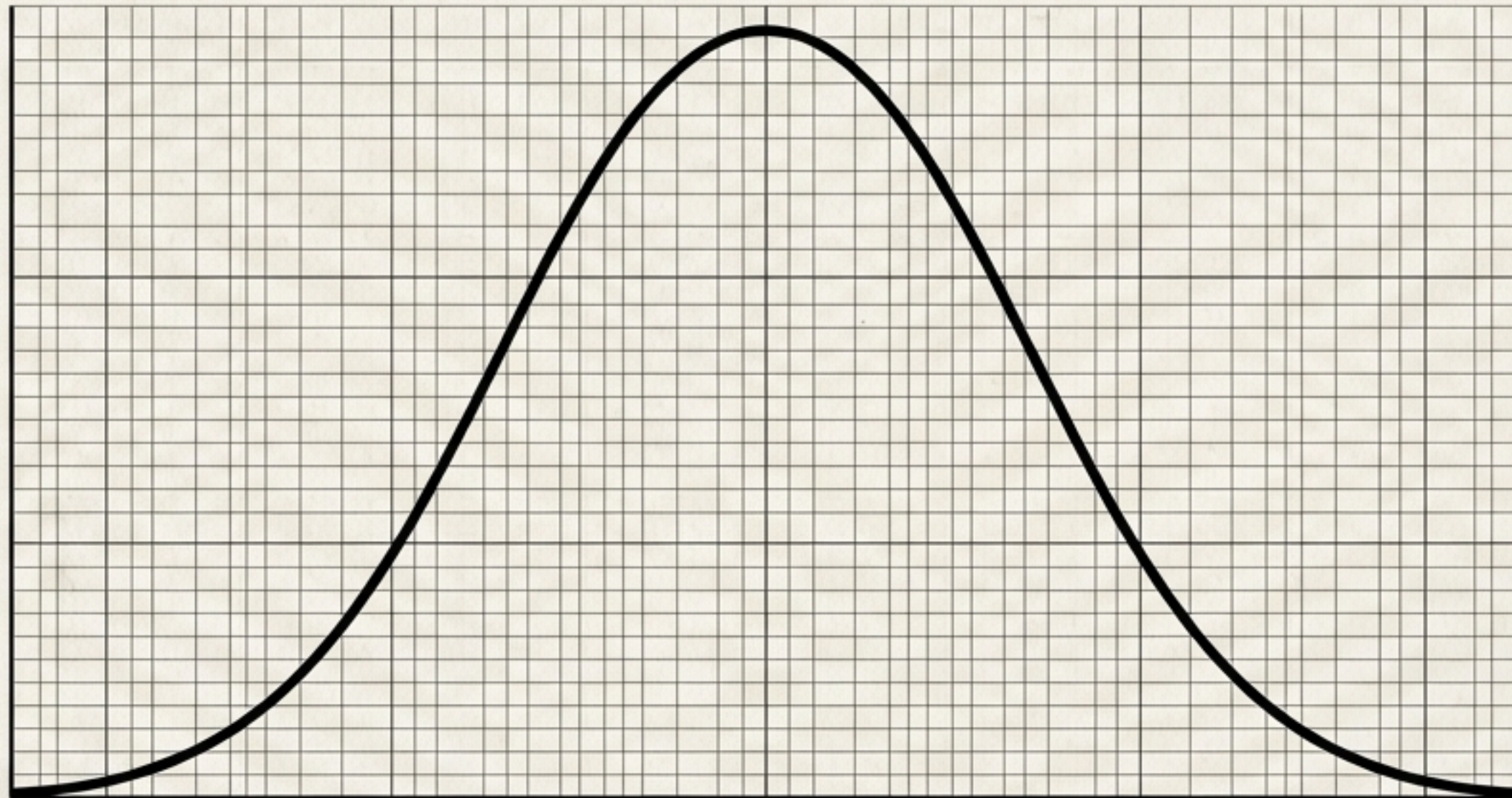


The Algernon-Gordon Effect

A Clinical Case Study of Flowers for Algernon by Daniel Keyes



Subject: Artificial Intelligence Enhancement.
Format: Progress Report Analysis.
Date: 1959/1966.

Phase I: The Baseline (IQ 68)



**Procedure
Candidates**



"I want to be smart.
My mother told me to
be smart."



Narrative Arc Start

Bell Curve

Phase II: The Test & The Maze

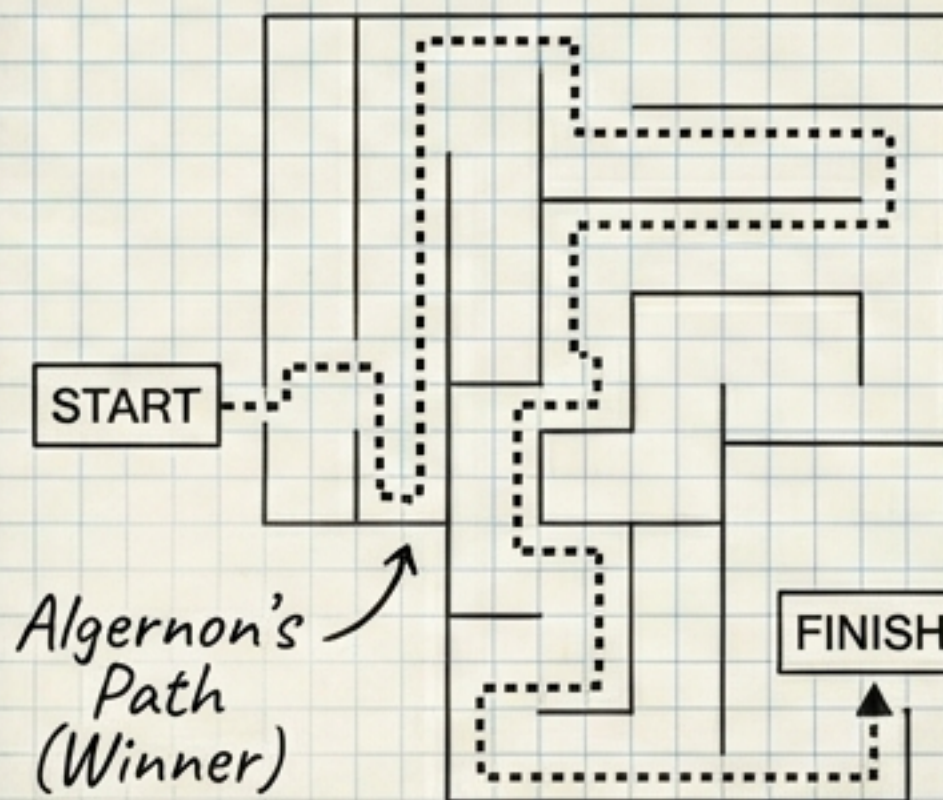
The Test: March 3



*Subject sees nothing.
Fears failure.*

Social Context:
Charlie believes
his coworkers are
friends. He is
unaware of the
idiom "Pulling a
Charlie Gordon"
(to make a stupid
mistake).

The Maze: March 29



Narrative Arc Start

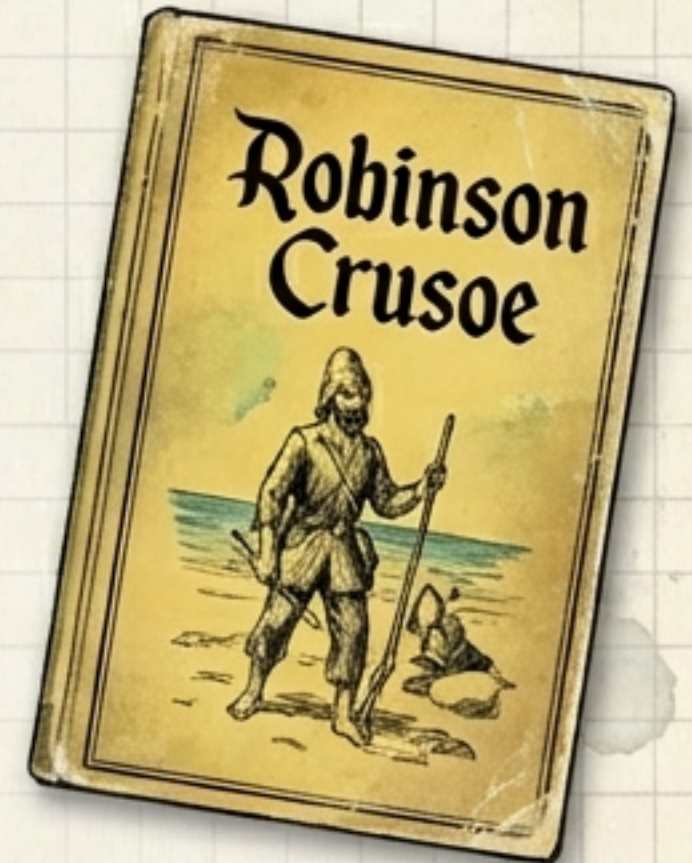
Bell Curve

Phase II: The Ascent (Awakening)

"I never knew before that Joe and Frank and the others liked to have me around just to make fun of me."

The Loss of Innocence

April 6: Charlie beats Algernon



Narrative Arc Start

Bell Curve

Theme: Man Playing God



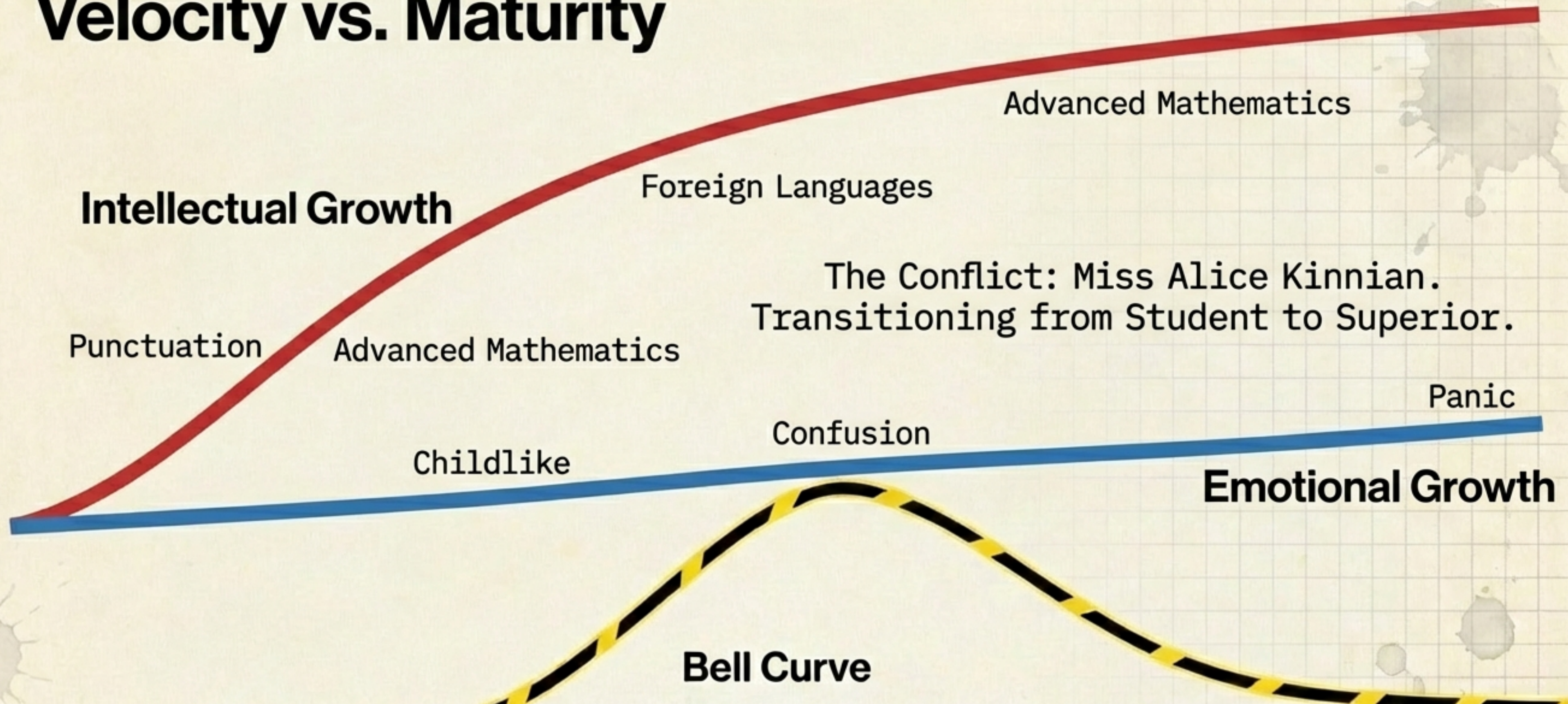
Fanny Birden's Argument:
It is not meant for man
to know more than was
given to him by the Lord.
The fruit of the tree
of knowledge causes
the loss of paradise.



Bell Curve

Consequence: Charlie is fired from Donner's Bakery. Intelligence creates alienation.

Velocity vs. Maturity



Trauma Trigger: Recovered memories of Rose Gordon create physical nausea during intimacy.

Phase III: The Peak (Genius / Isolation)



The Realization:
The “Giants” of
science are
ordinary men.
Nemur is a “couch
potato” intellectual;
Strauss is limited.

The Ivory Tower:
Charlie is removed from
the human experience. He
is treated as a
specimen—an object
created by scientists, not a
human being with a past.

Consequence: Charlie's extreme intelligence leads to profound alienation
and the perception of him as an experiment rather than a person.

The Chicago Convention



Chicago

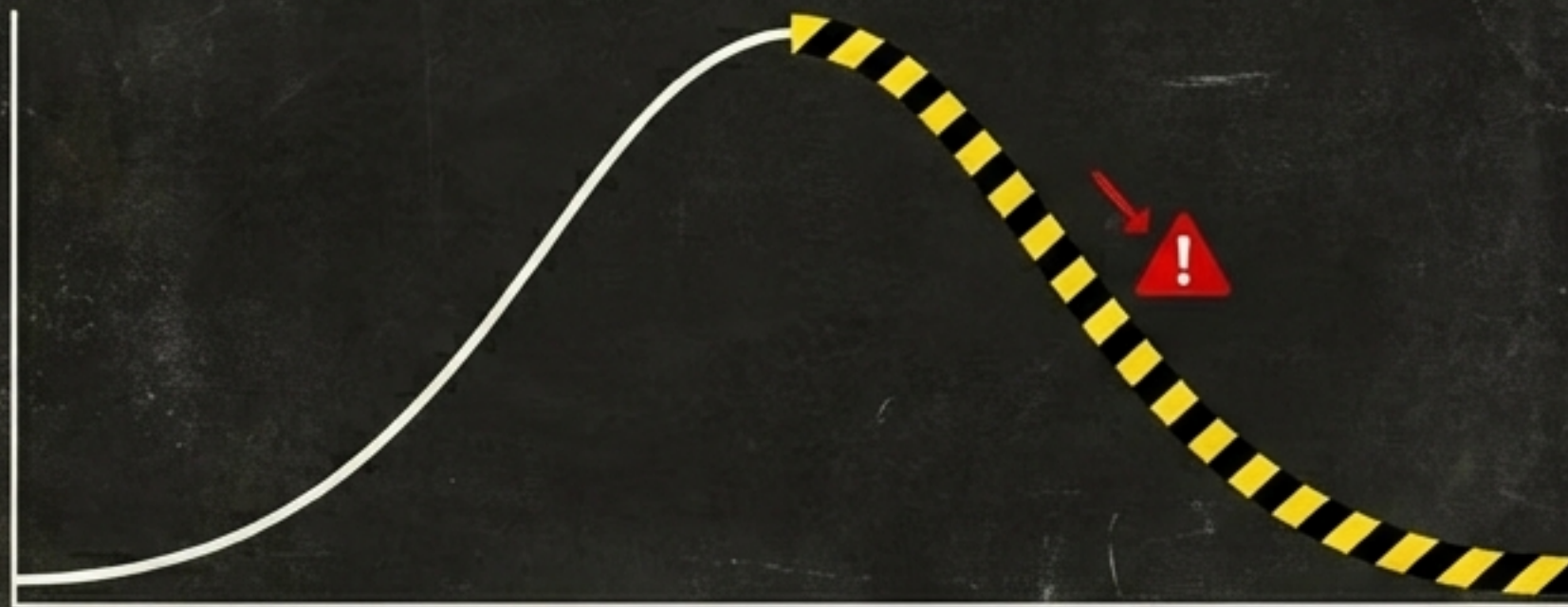
The Rebellion: Resenting his treatment as a success story before the data is complete, Charlie releases Algernon and flees.

New York

Paradigm Shift: Charlie takes control of the experiment. He transitions from subject to researcher.

The Algernon-Gordon Effect

Artificially induced intelligence
deteriorates at a rate of time directly
proportional to the quantity of the increase.



The Discovery: Algernon becomes erratic and aggressive.
The hypothesis is confirmed: The faster the rise, the faster the fall.

Helvetica Now Display

Phase IV: The Descent (Race Against Time)



Courier Prime

Algernon: Deceased Sept 15.
Autopsy reveals decreased brain
weight and smoothing of fissures.

Courier Prime

The Split Self: Charlie begins to hallucinate the “Old Charlie”—a watcher in the window waiting to reclaim his body.

Courier Prime

Emotional State: Urgency. Anger. The desperate need to leave a legacy before the darkness returns.

Helvetica Now Display

Connection in the Descent

Alice Kinnian (The Past/Intellect)



Emotional baggage.
Connection to the
experiment.

Fay Lillman (The Present/Impulse)



Pure impulse.
Uninhibited.
She does not know
"Old Charlie" or
"Genius Charlie,"
only the man in
the moment.

Fay allows Charlie to bypass his sexual hang-ups by removing the intellectual pressure.

Closing the Loops



The Father (Matt)

Unrecognized.
Weakness vs. Love.



The Mother (Rose)

Pride -> Senility ->
Trauma.



The Sister (Norma)

Regret and joyous
reunion.

Resolution: Charlie gains a fragmented peace with his origins before he forgets them.

Fragmentation (Oct - Nov)

FRAGMENTATION

"I remember I did
something but I dont
remember what."

Forgetfulness

Motor Control Loss

Inability to read scientific papers

Phase V: The Return (Regressed State)



The Shift

Charlie returns to his janitorial job.
A new employee, Meyer Klaus, mocks him.

The Defense

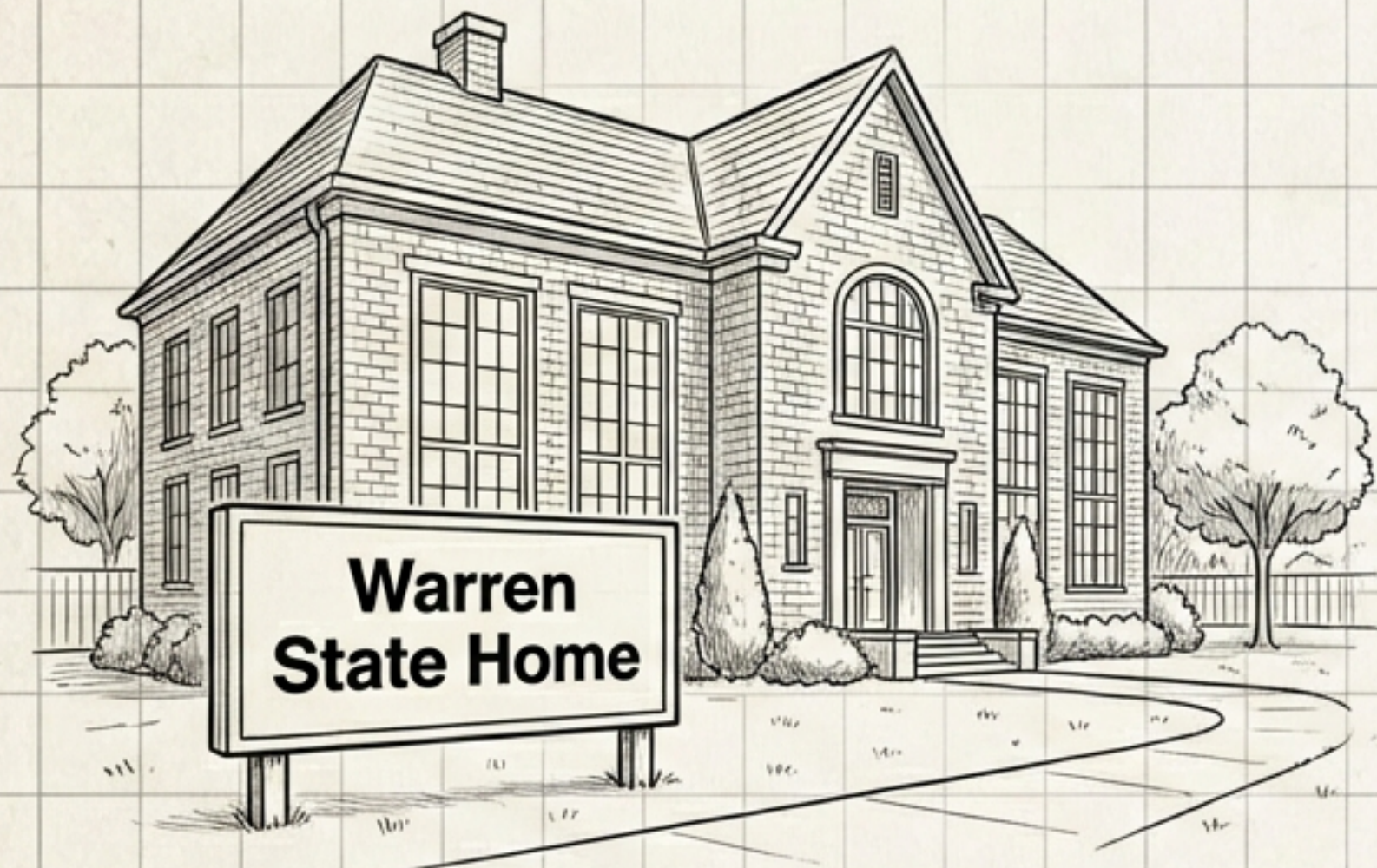
Joe Carp and Frank Reilly—former tormentors—stand up for him. "If anybody bothers you... you call me or Frank."

Theme

True friendship involves protection and acceptance, not just shared laughter.

Baseline

The Final Choice



Motivation

Charlie commits himself to the Warren State Home. He refuses to be an object of pity for Alice or the others.

"I'm going some place where nobody knows that I was once a genius."

Baseline

Mr. Winslow and the staff treat patients with fundamental human dignity.

Analysis: The Cave & The Window

Post-Op: Seeing the Light (Truth).
It is blinding, painful, and reveals
the grotesque nature of reality.

"I am like a man who
has been half-asleep...
and now I am awake."

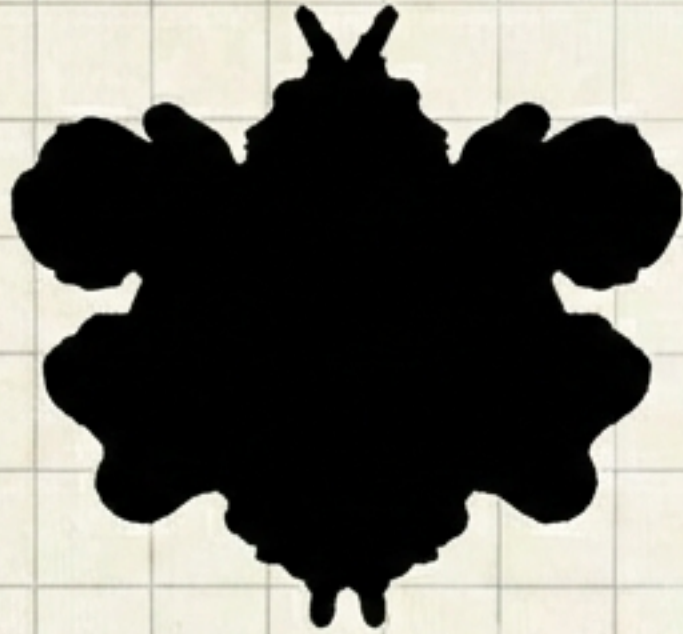
Pre-Op: The Dark (Ignorance).
Happy in the shadows,
unaware of the mockery.



Baseline

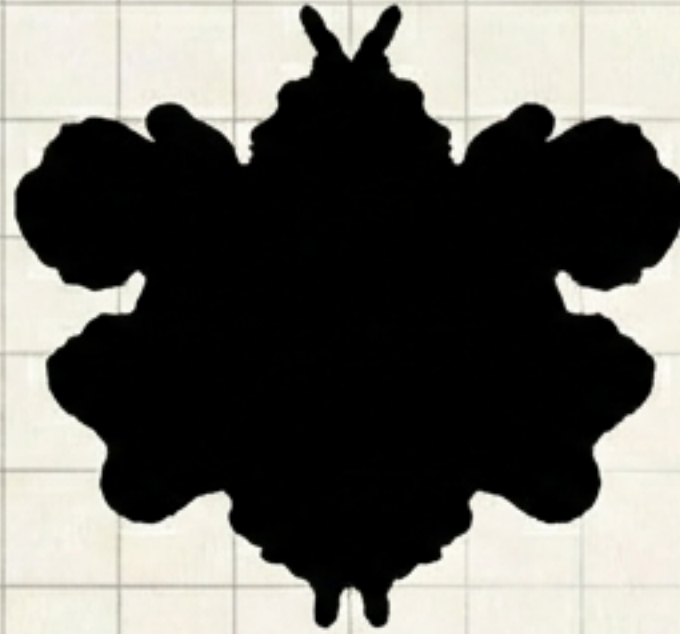
Motif: The Rorschach Test

Stage 1 (Low IQ)



Nothing
Fear of Failure
Trust in Authority

Stage 2 (High IQ)



Fraud
Psychological Trick
Questioning Science

Stage 3 (Regressed)



Pleasing the Tester
Simple Acceptance



Perception is fluid. The object doesn't change; the viewer does.

Theme: Scientific Hubris



Key Question: Does increasing intelligence increase humanity?

Dr. Nemur:

"I made you."

Sees Charlie as a created object.

Dr. Guarino (The Charlatan):

Treated the child Charlie
as a human being.

Baseline

Tampering with natural design comes with a heavy spiritual price.

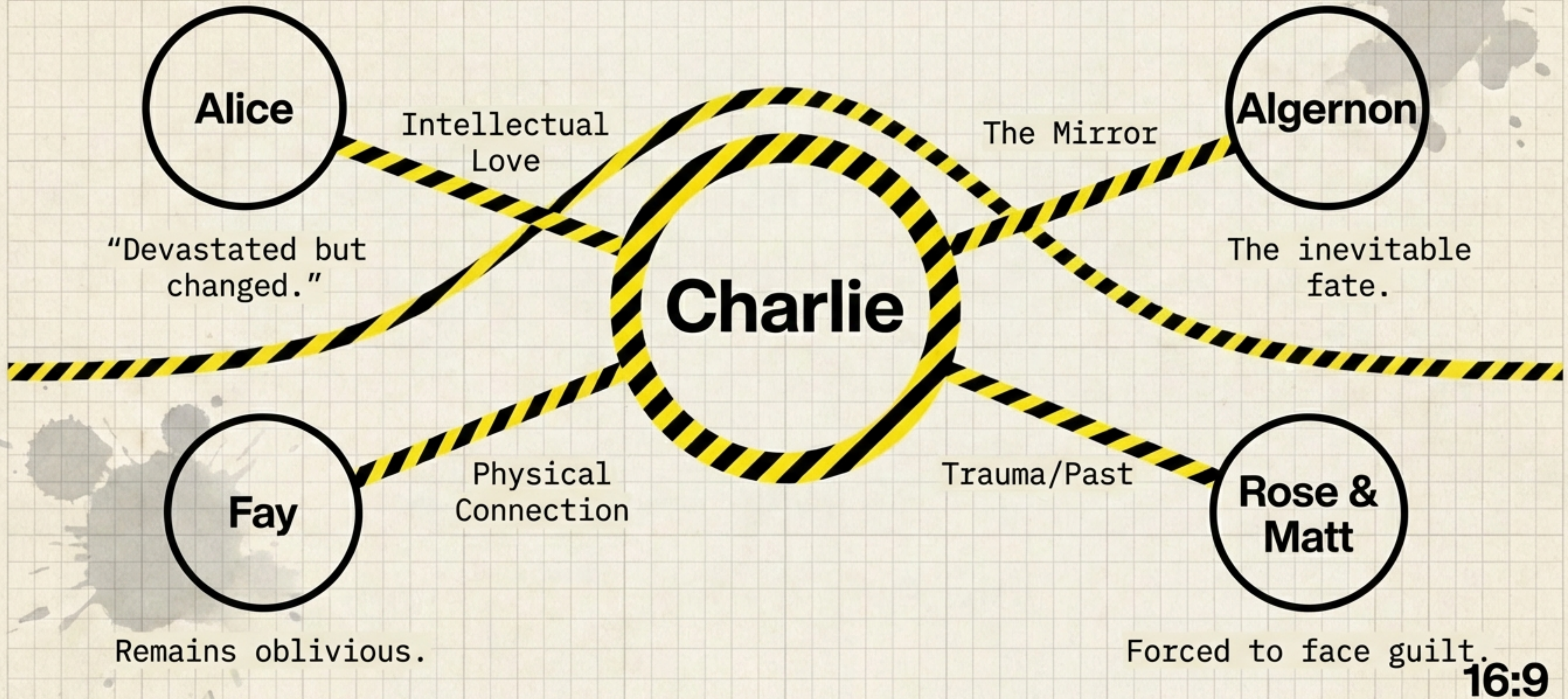
The Core Thesis

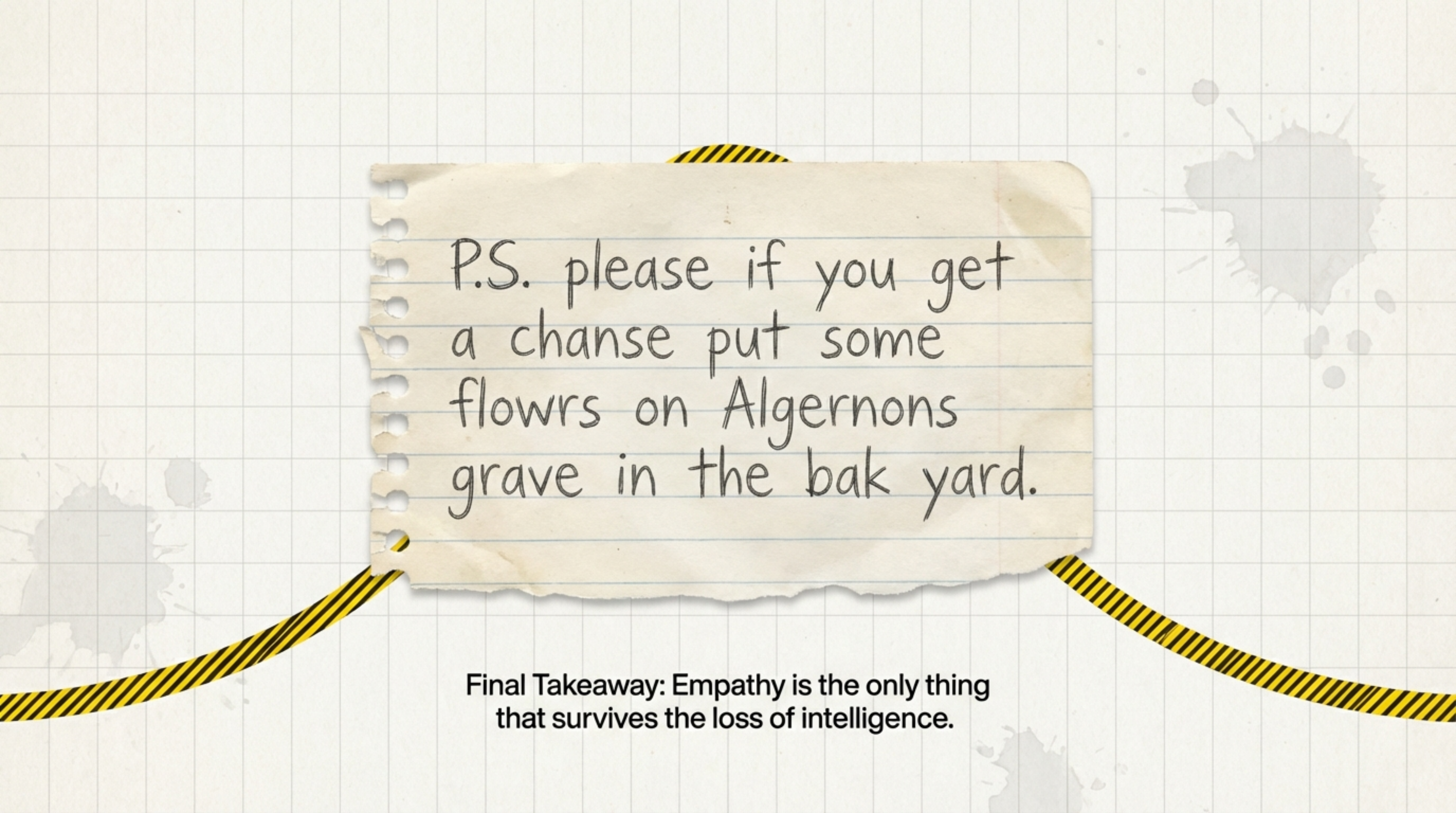
"Intelligence and education that hasn't been tempered by human affection isn't worth a damn."

Charlie Gordon (The Peak).

**Charlie's genius did not bring him happiness;
it brought him loneliness.**

Character Web





P.S. please if you get
a chance put some
flowrs on Algernons
grave in the bak yard.

**Final Takeaway: Empathy is the only thing
that survives the loss of intelligence.**